The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

21st January 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Pump prime

Meaning: To stimulate or encourage an activity or process, especially economic growth.
Hindi Meaning: आर्थिक गतिविधि को प्रेरित करना
Synonyms: Stimulate, boost, encourage
Antonyms: Suppress, hinder, obstruct
Example: The government plans to pump prime the economy by increasing infrastructure investments.

2. Stoke

Meaning: To encourage or incite a strong emotion or activity.
Hindi Meaning: भड़काना , बढ़ावा देना
Synonyms: Fuel, provoke, incite
Antonyms: Quell, calm, suppress
Example: The new policy is expected to stoke demand for housing projects in rural areas.

VOCABULARY

3. Rampant (अनियंत्रित)

Meaning: Spreading or growing quickly and uncontrolled, especially in a way that is harmful or unwelcome.
Synonyms: Uncontrolled, unrestrained, widespread.
Antonyms: Controlled, restrained, limited.
Example: Corruption was rampant in the organization, affecting its efficiency and public trust.

4. Flaky

Meaning: Unreliable or not dependable; in the context, uncertain or inconsistent.
Hindi Meaning: अविश्वसनीय , अस्थिर
Synonyms: Uncertain, unreliable, shaky
Antonyms: Reliable, dependable, certain
Example: Investors are hesitant due to the flaky demand in the urban housing market.

VOCABULARY

5. Expediting

Meaning: Making a process happen sooner or be accomplished more quickly.
Hindi Meaning: तेजी से करना, शीघ्रता लाना
Synonyms: Accelerate, hasten, facilitate
Antonyms: Delay, slow, hinder
Example: The authority is expediting approvals for new infrastructure projects.

6. Conducive

Meaning: Making a situation or outcome more likely to occur.
Hindi Meaning: अनुकूल, सहायक
Synonyms: Favorable, beneficial, supportive
Antonyms: Detrimental, adverse, unfavorable
Example: The low interest rates are conducive to increased borrowing for businesses.

VOCABULARY

7. Waning

Meaning: Decreasing in strength, intensity, or importance.
Hindi Meaning: घटता हुआ, कम होता हुआ
Synonyms: Diminishing, declining, fading
Antonyms: Increasing, growing, intensifying
Example: The waning demand for luxury goods has affected the retail sector.

8. Imperatives

Meaning: Essential or urgent things that require immediate attention.
Hindi Meaning: अनिवार्यताएँ , आवश्यकताएँ
Synonyms: Necessities, obligations, requirements
Antonyms: Options, unnecessities, non-essentials
Example: Balancing fiscal consolidation with development imperatives is a challenging task.

VOCABULARY

9. Assertiveness (दृढ़ता)

Meaning: The quality of being confident and self-assured without being aggressive.
Synonyms: Confidence, decisiveness, boldness.
Antonyms: Timidity, hesitation, submissiveness.
Example: Her assertiveness during the meeting impressed her colleagues.

10. Rectitude

Meaning: Morally correct behavior or thinking; righteousness.
Hindi Meaning: शुद्धता, नैतिकता
Synonyms: Integrity, honesty, uprightness
Antonyms: Corruption, dishonesty, immorality
Example: Fiscal rectitude is vital for maintaining economic credibility.

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Take on
Meaning: To accept a responsibility or challenge; to hire someone.

2. Break into
Meaning: To enter a place by force; to start doing something, especially in a particular field or industry.

3. Call up
Meaning: To make a phone call; to summon someone for a task, often military service.

4. Come up with
Meaning: To think of or produce an idea or solution.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. Wool over the eyes

Meaning - to trick or deceive someone.

2. Jump through hoops

Meaning - to do a complicated things in order to get or achieve something

3. Up in the air

Meaning - (of a plan or issue) still to be settled; unresolved.

VOCABULARY

4. By the book

Meaning - exactly according to the rules.

5. To get down to business

Meaning - to start the work that has to be done.

Article for Reading

Capex quandary: on the economic data, policy

Since the COVID-19 pandemic, the Centre has been using public capital expenditure on infrastructure to pump prime the economic recovery. The mantra has been that infrastructure building will stoke demand for products such as cement and steel, generate jobs in construction, and together trigger a strong multiplier effect on the economy, eventually creating conducive conditions for private investors to plan greenfield and brownfield projects. In Budget 2024-25, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said the government will endeavour to maintain strong fiscal support for infrastructure over the next five years, in conjunction with imperatives of other priorities and fiscal consolidation. She announced ₹11.11 lakh crore of capex spends this year, amounting to 3.4% of GDP. That goal is unlikely to be attained partly due to spending curbs in the poll-affected first quarter. While industry has urged the Centre to continue the capex push in 2025-26 as well, it has failed to respond to the government's constant nudges and persuasions to ramp up their own operations.

Data show that two of this year's first three quarters have recorded a notable sequential decline in private investment plans, particularly by domestic industry. In Q1, private capex plans dropped to multi-year lows, and though the July-September quarter recorded a recovery in investment intentions, that uptick has dissipated in Q3. Projects Today data suggest domestic investments' value dropped 1.4% from Q2, while new projects' value dropped over 22% from a year ago as per the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy. There are many factors playing on corporate risk-taking capacity — weak Q2 results, global uncertainties, spiking costs and waning demand in more lucrative urban markets. Going by current indications, including the early bird Q3 results, demand has not really improved, nor is there ostensible pressure on factory capacities to warrant expansions. For a sustainable breakout from this slowdown, private capital should take the driving seat because there are limits to enhancing public capex while maintaining fiscal rectitude and providing for myriad welfare schemes.

The government must accept that exhortations to industry are unlikely to spur fresh outlays, and incentives focused on themes such as import-substitution are insufficient. Not one new rupee will be deployed if a project is unviable and demand flaky. Policy focus should remain firmly on ensuring the ground is ripe to instigate investments and easing the realisation of such plans into billowing chimneys and new jobs. For that, boosting incomes and consumption is critical as is expediting macro- and micro-level reforms. That an economic policy framework outlining next generation reforms, promised in the Budget, has not been heard of since then, is not very comforting.

Summary

Since the COVID-19 pandemic, the Indian government has relied on public capital expenditure (capex) in infrastructure to stimulate economic recovery, creating jobs and demand for key materials like cement and steel. Despite the Finance Minister's commitment to maintaining fiscal support for infrastructure development, the private sector has not responded adequately to calls for increased investment. Data reveals declining private capex plans due to various factors such as weak corporate earnings, global uncertainties, and insufficient demand. While public spending has its limits due to fiscal constraints and welfare priorities, private investment must play a more significant role in driving sustainable growth. The government needs to shift its focus to creating favorable conditions for investments by boosting consumption, expediting reforms, and ensuring project viability. However, the lack of progress on promised economic policy reforms is concerning.

The tone of the passage is analytical and cautionary. It evaluates the current economic situation critically, highlights challenges, and emphasizes the need for strategic reforms and policy action.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What has been the trend in private investment in the current fiscal year?

a) A steady rise across all quarters.
b) A consistent decline in private capex intentions.
c) Fluctuations, with a decline in Q1, a recovery in Q2, and another drop in Q3.
d) A surge in domestic private investments despite global uncertainties.
e) None of the above

Question 2:
Why does the passage argue that public capex alone cannot sustain economic recovery?

a) Public capex often leads to inflation, negating its benefits.
b) Fiscal constraints limit the government's ability to continue increasing capex indefinitely.
c) Public capex has no impact on private investment decisions.
d) Infrastructure projects are not viable in the current economic climate.
e) None of the above

Question 3:
What is suggested as the key to stimulating private investment, according to the passage?

a) Increased tax incentives for import-substitution projects.
b) Higher public spending on welfare schemes.
c) Reducing global uncertainties through trade agreements.
d) Boosting incomes and consumption while expediting reforms.
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

Go, kho kho, go: On boosting sport with a rural heart

Kho kho is not, by any stretch of imagination, among the world's most popular sports. Even in India, where the game is said to have originated several centuries ago, it has not yet caught the imagination. Not many would have noticed India winning the men's and women's titles at the inaugural Kho Kho World Cup in New Delhi on Sunday. Pratik Waikar's men and Priyanka Ingle's women flourished but their collective achievements should not be cause to gloss over the fact that kho kho is not a global sport yet. Indeed, the conduct of the World Cup and India winning both the titles could offer a boost to this particular game with a rural heart. Since India is not really a major power in international sport at large, any world title is a welcome addition to the not-so-overflowing cupboard. There are, of course, a few sports in which India is a superpower, such as cricket and chess.

Indian cricket may be going through its lowest phase in recent times — notwithstanding the triumph in the T20 World Cup last year — but in the mind game on 64 squares, India's Grandmasters have been authoring one success story after another, the latest being D. Gukesh winning the World chess championship and Koneru Humpy regaining the women's World rapid championship. India's brilliant minds, however, have not received the acclaim or support they deserve, especially after their historic double gold at the Chess Olympiad back in September, from the government or corporate houses. The government could do a lot to raise the profile of games such as kho kho, chess and Olympic disciplines. The disappointment at the Paris Olympics last year, where India failed to win even a single gold and finished 71st, below Pakistan and Kyrgyzstan, was another stark reminder of the state of Indian sport. India won six medals but its performance was below expectations. India's various sports federations need to review their own functioning.

And they could, in fact, learn lessons from how the Board of Control for Cricket in India, for all the criticism directed against it, is running its sport, improving infrastructure and sharing the growth in revenue with players. India may largely be a single-sport country, unlike the United States or Australia, but a game such as kabaddi, with its Pro Kabaddi League, has shown that there is scope for Indian sport on television beyond cricket. The governments, at the Centre and the States, could also do better by developing infrastructure and nurturing varied sport such as kho kho. It is also time to find out if Khelo India is justifying the huge budgetary spend.

Question 4:
Why does the passage criticize India's performance at the Paris Olympics?

a) India finished below smaller nations like Pakistan and Kyrgyzstan.
b) India failed to qualify for major sporting events.
c) The government did not allocate enough funds for training athletes.
d) India's performance in team events was particularly poor.
e) None of the above

Question 5

What does the passage suggest about the state of Indian sports federations?

a) They are more efficient than other countries' federations.
b) They should emulate the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI).
c) They have too much focus on cricket at the expense of other sports.
d) They lack sufficient autonomy from government influence.
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question:

Original Text:

A social security net refers to a system of government programs and policies designed to provide financial assistance and support to individuals and families, particularly those facing economic hardships. This framework typically includes initiatives such as unemployment benefits, healthcare services, food assistance, pensions for the elderly, disability benefits, and housing support. The primary objective of a social security net is to ensure a basic standard of living and mitigate the adverse effects of poverty, unemployment, or unforeseen crises. In modern societies, social security programs play a vital role in promoting social equity and economic stability. By redistributing resources, they help bridge the gap between the rich and the

poor, thereby reducing income inequality. Furthermore, such systems contribute to economic growth by maintaining consumer demand during periods of recession. For instance, when individuals receive unemployment benefits, they can continue to spend on essential goods and services, preventing a severe economic downturn. However, the effectiveness of a social security net depends on several factors, including the efficiency of implementation, the adequacy of benefits, and the inclusivity of coverage. Critics often argue that overly generous benefits may discourage people from seeking employment, leading to dependency on government aid. On the other hand, insufficient support can leave vulnerable populations exposed to the risks of extreme poverty. Governments face the challenge of balancing fiscal sustainability with the need to provide robust social security programs. As populations age and economic uncertainties grow, reforming and strengthening social security systems becomes imperative. Innovations such as digital technologies and targeted subsidies can enhance efficiency and ensure that aid reaches those who need it the most.

Precis:

A social security net comprises government programs providing financial aid for those in economic distress, including unemployment benefits, healthcare, and pensions. It aims to ensure a basic living standard, promote social equity, and stabilize economies by reducing poverty and income inequality. Effective implementation and adequate benefits are critical for success, though challenges like dependency and fiscal sustainability persist. To address growing demands, governments must reform these systems using innovative technologies to ensure inclusivity and efficiency.

- **Write an email to your manager requesting leave for five days due to a personal emergency. Ensure you specify the dates, the reason for the leave (optional), and any arrangements you have made for your responsibilities during your absence.**

To: …..@gmail.com

Subject: Request for Leave Due to Personal Emergency

Dear [Manager's Name],

I hope this email finds you well. I am writing to request leave from [start date] to [end date] due to a personal emergency that requires my immediate attention. I apologize for any inconvenience this may cause and assure you that I have taken steps to ensure a smooth transition during my absence.

To minimize the impact of my absence:

[Briefly outline arrangements you've made, e.g., "I have briefed [Colleague's Name] about my current tasks and deadlines, and they have kindly agreed to oversee them while I am away."]

[Optionally mention specific tasks, e.g., "I have completed [Task A] and prepared detailed notes for [Task B] to ensure continuity."] Please let me know if there are any additional steps I should take before my leave. I am reachable via email or phone in case of urgent matters.

Thank you for your understanding and support.

Best regards,
[Your Full Name]

Match the column

1. Wool over the eyes
2. Jump through hoops
3. Up in the air
4. By the book
5. To get down to business

A. to do a complicated things in order to get or achieve something
B. exactly according to the rules
C. to start the work that has to be done
D. unresolved
E. to trick or deceive someone

Answer:

1-e

2-a

3-d

4-b

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Pump prime:
2. Stoke:
3. Rampant:
4. Flaky:
5. Expediting:
6. Conducive:
7. Waning:
8. Imperatives:
9. Assertiveness:
10. Rectitude:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage outlines the trend clearly:

"In Q1, private capex plans dropped to multi-year lows... the July-September quarter recorded a recovery... that uptick has dissipated in Q3."

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Incorrect: The trend is not steady; it fluctuates.

b) Incorrect: While Q1 and Q3 saw declines, Q2 experienced a recovery, so the trend is not consistently downward.

d) Incorrect: There is no indication of a surge; instead, private investment has shown weakness.

2.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage highlights fiscal limitations as a critical concern:
"There are limits to enhancing public capex while maintaining fiscal rectitude and providing for myriad welfare schemes."

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Incorrect: Inflation is not mentioned as a consequence of public capex in the passage.
c) Incorrect: The passage discusses how public capex aims to stimulate private investment, even if it hasn’t succeeded fully.
d) Incorrect: Infrastructure projects are viable but require complementary private investment to sustain recovery.

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage explicitly calls for focusing on incomes and consumption:
"Boosting incomes and consumption is critical as is expediting macro- and micro-level reforms."

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Incorrect: Import-substitution incentives are deemed insufficient in the passage:
“Incentives focused on themes such as import-substitution are insufficient.”
b) Incorrect: While welfare schemes are important, they are not presented as the primary solution for stimulating private investment.
c) Incorrect: Global uncertainties are mentioned as a challenge but not something directly controllable by the Centre.

4.

Ans: a

Explanation:

The passage specifically states:

"The disappointment at the Paris Olympics last year, where India failed to win even a single gold and finished 71st, below Pakistan and Kyrgyzstan..."

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

b) Incorrect: The passage does not discuss India failing to qualify for events.

c) Incorrect: Lack of funds is not mentioned as a reason for poor performance at the Olympics.

d) Incorrect: Team events are not singled out as a problem.

5.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage explicitly mentions:

"India’s various sports federations... could, in fact, learn lessons from how the Board of Control for Cricket in India, for all the criticism directed against it, is running its sport, improving infrastructure and sharing the growth in revenue with players."

Why Other Options Are Incorrect:

a) Incorrect: The passage does not claim Indian federations are more efficient than others.

c) Incorrect: The passage criticizes cricket’s dominance but does not attribute this directly to the federations.

d) Incorrect: Autonomy is not discussed as a problem.

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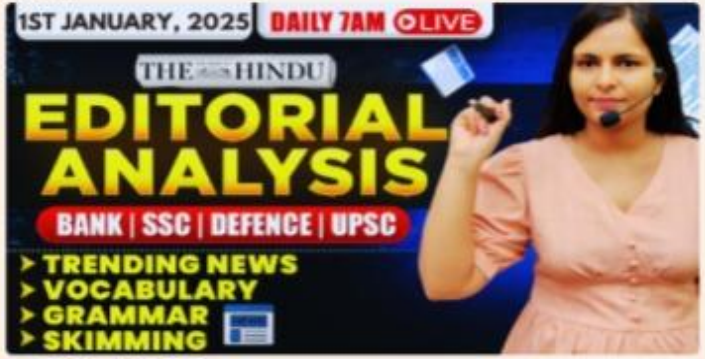

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